

Jihadism and terrorism

The concept of jihad in Islam, in simple terms, is the religious duty of all Muslims to struggle and resist in order to protect the faith from harm. In the latter part of the 20th century, this was taken by radical Islam as a call to arms, especially after the establishment of the state of Israel and the spread of Western-style democracy into Islamic countries.

Outright conflict was, until the 21st century, confined largely to the Middle Eastern countries, but terrorism increasingly became a threat elsewhere. A turning point was the September 11 attacks on the World Trade Center in New York City in 2001, coordinated by the Al Qaeda network. This marked the beginning of a global 'War on Terror' declared by President George W. Bush, which in turn was met with further terrorist attacks on Western targets, and the recruitment of Islamic 'jihadists', not only from Islamic countries but also from those 'radicalized' by influential fundamentalist preachers in the West.

